

SECTION 7

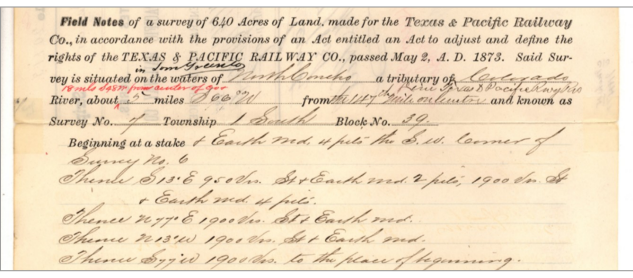
Block 39, Township 1 South, Texas & Pacific Railway Company Survey · Abstract 34 · Midland County, Texas

ONE SQUARE MILE · Desk Edition. Compiled from records, not walked.

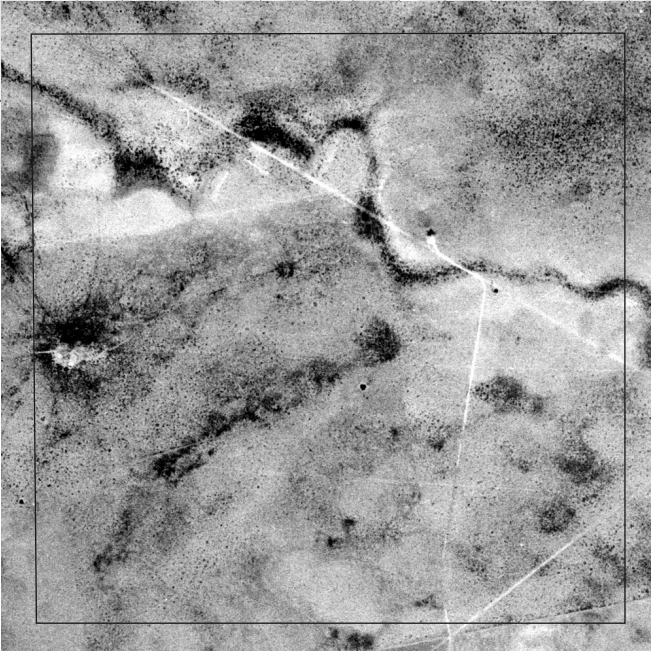
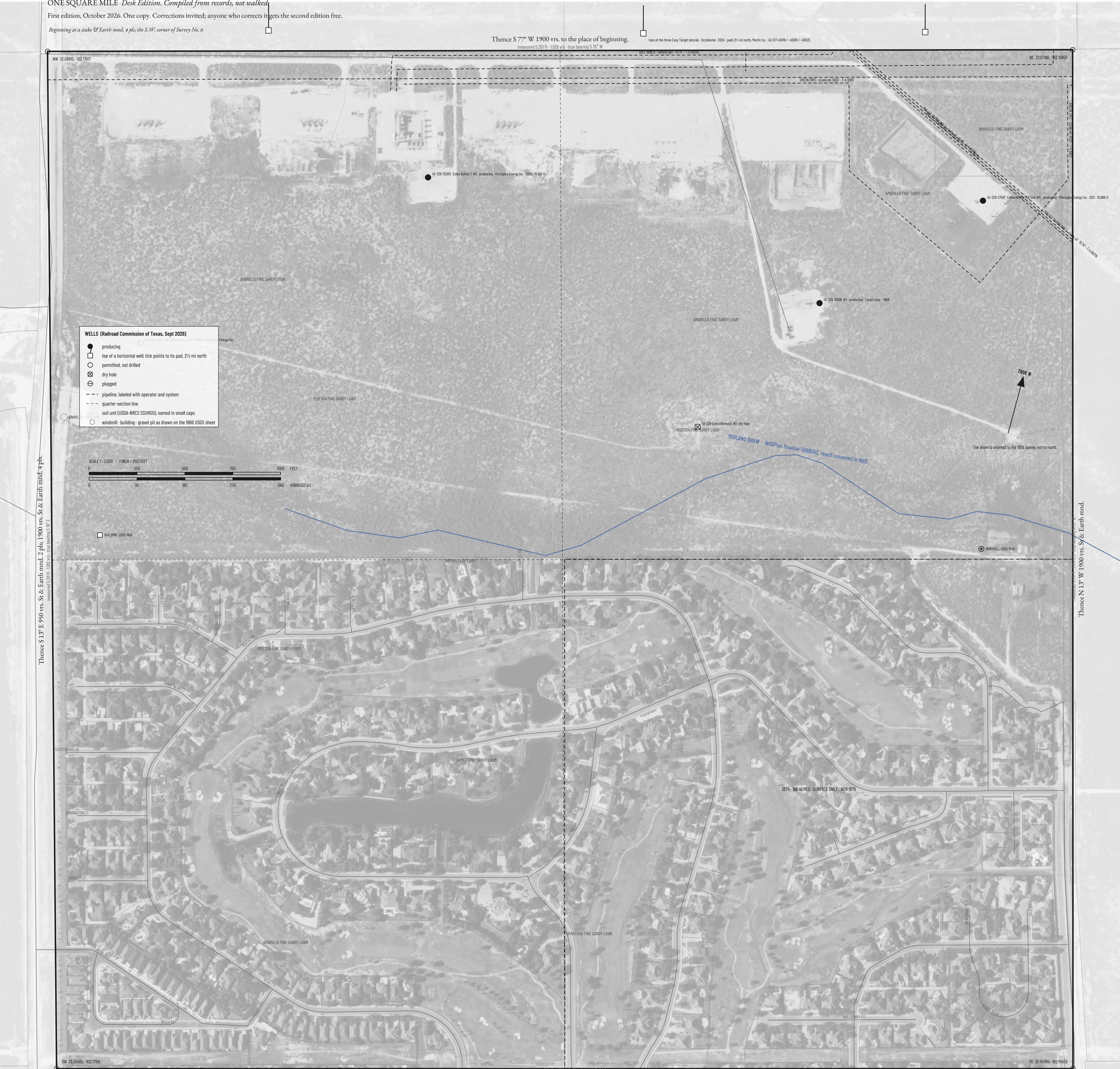
First edition, October 1906. One copy. Corrections invited; anyone who corrects it gets the second edition free.

Beginning at a stake & Earth mound, 4 pls, the S.W. corner of Survey No. 6

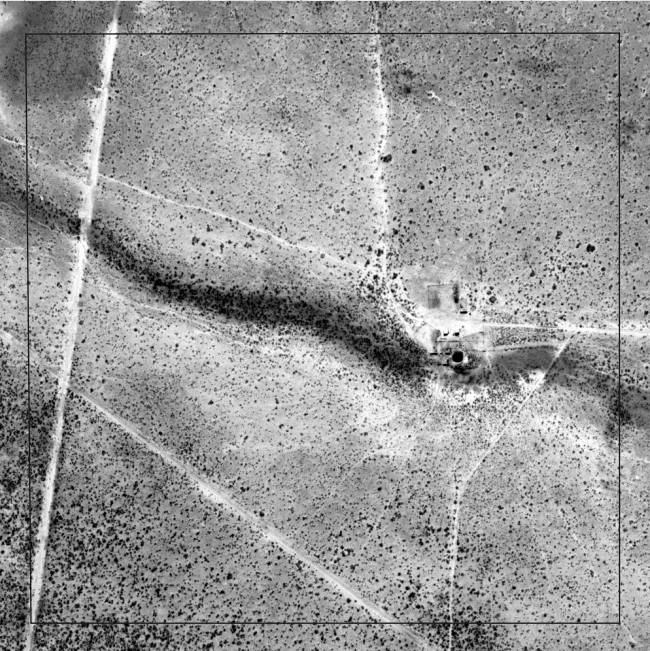
Surveyed 1 February 1876 and docketed under Martin County. Corrected to Midland County in red ink, 1887, two years after Midland County was organized. The county this ground sits in was itself a correction. On this sheet, red means the record disagreed with itself, or ran out.



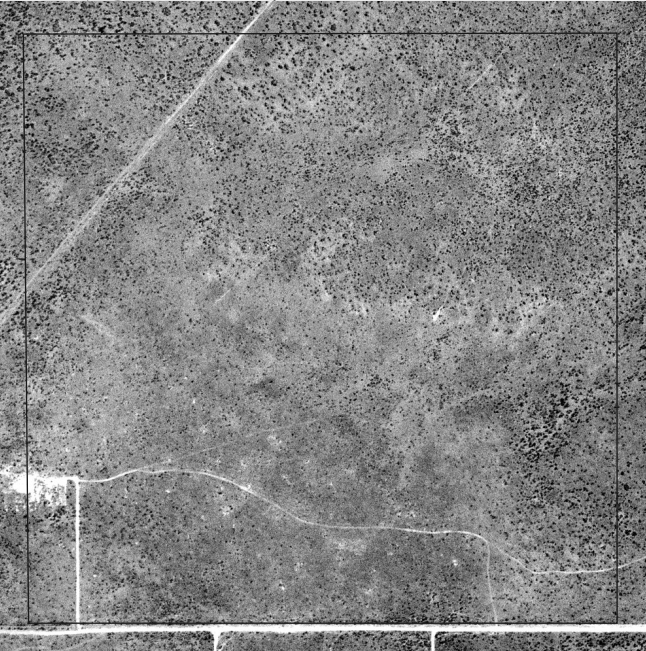
Powell's field notes, Feb 1876, as filed. "Martin", struck. GLO Bear Scrip File 020113.



1954 USGS single frame, 1:63,000, 2 May 1954. Open range; the draw plain across the north. Placement approximate, error over 500 ft.



1965 USGS single frame, 1:21,000, 20 Feb 1965. Still range; a road on the west line, a pad at the draw. Placement approximate, ±300–500 ft.



1974 USGS single frame, 1:29,000, 19 Feb 1974. First graded corridors. Placement ±300 ft, two control points on the south-line road.



1984 USGS NAIP, 28 Oct 1984. Streets and a golf course under construction, south half, ±50 ft.



1995 USGS NAIP color-infrared, 19 Dec 1995. Course mature, south half built-out. North half still range, ±50 ft.



2022 USGS NAIP, 24 Sep 2022. Built out to the plat. North half: paths, gathering lines, a caliche yard. Orthorectified.

CHAIN OF TITLE, 1876–1983 · complete, no gaps

1876. Surveyed 1 Feb by deputy surveyor W.C. Powell, chain carriers L.E. Wright and E.C. Bennett, “on the waters of North Concho.” Bearings in varas. Filed at the General Land Office 27 Dec.

1876. Land Scrip No. 3123, 25 May: the Texas & Pacific has built 203 miles, 4,624 feet of railroad. This section is part of what that construction earned. Odd-numbered — railroad land, not school land.

1883. Patented 15 Dec to Texas and Pacific Railway Co. Patent 540, Vol. 68, p. 503. 640 acres.

1906. Charles J. Canda, trustee of the Texas Pacific Land Trust → Mrs. Mary T. Edwards, 640 acres. Recorded 6 Jan, Deed Records 12/54. Three notes of \$795.

1911. Mary T. Edwards and heirs → S.H. Holloway, with Sections 6, 8, 17, 18; buyer assumes the 1906 notes. Four months later Holloway → S.W. Estes. The Estes years begin.

1921. Armita Estes → Thelma Estes, 7 June. DR. 30/144. The whole section; her 1923 deeds of trust cover all 640 acres.

1940. Thelma Estes Brown and W.T. Brown → Magnolia Pipe Line Company, right-of-way across the 640 acres, 2 Dec. DR. 67/531. That is the pipeline on the 1954 and 1966 USGS sheets.

1941. Family partition, 31 Oct. four instruments in a row. Thelma Estes Brown → Aldredge Estes, Section 7 (DR. 70/294); Aldredge → Thelma, Section 6, the same day. Both had taken land from S.W. and Armita. Kin, plainly; the records never say how. Thelma died in 1983 at 80, in Laguna Hills, California.

1953, 1970. Ethel Estes, Aldredge’s wife, then widow: a royalty deed on the 640 acres to Stanolind Oil & Gas; an oil and gas lease to Pan American Petroleum.

1976. Ethel Aldredge Estes → her three children, 14 Dec. DR. 615/436–438.

1978. The Estes family → Midland West Corporation, 21–22 Nov, three deeds. Surface only; the minerals stay with the family. A deed of trust runs back to Mrs. Estes on the SE¼.

1979. The Estes heirs and Midland West → Pioneer Natural Gas Company, right-of-way, October. DR. 673/712–714. Today’s 16-in gas line; ONEOK Westex is Pioneer’s successor.

1979. Midland West, about a dozen partners, opens the Green Tree course in July.

1980–81. Midland West → Hallico Inc. (incorporated May 1979; Neal Hall, president), a Midland homebuilder buying finished lots.

1982. 8 Jan. Midland West sells 20.345 acres — Lots 20–23, Block 6, the seed of Green Tree North — to The Greens, a joint venture of Hallico, Dovecote Inc., and BSD Inc., for \$1,348,425 cash, with a four-year build-or-recover clock and a promise to annex, plat, some pave, and pipe the land. DR. 731/258.

1982. Green Tree North plat recorded 1 Dec. Cabinet C, p. 134. Frank Mullins becomes majority owner of Midland West the same month.

1983. 26 Jan. the first Green Tree North lot is deeded to a homebuyer — Lot 18, Block 2, from Midland West. DR. 770/614. 1 March: the members buy the clubhouse and both courses from Midland West for more than \$6 million. Green Tree North — 297 acres, 220 lots, nine more holes — under construction, 85 lots pre-sold, First National Bank of Midland carrying the paper. Three years later a First National banker is convicted in federal court of hiding his own stake in Midland West while the bank lent it \$1.925 million.

1989. Ten acres at the northeast corner of the SE¼, deeded 15 Sept to the family’s ranch partnership. Still theirs.

The chain stops here. Sixty-seven years of one family; ninety-nine years of ranch. Everything since is somebody’s home and is not this map’s business.

THE GROUND

Water. Ogallala aquifer 100–180 ft below the section. One City of Midland well inside the line, 147 ft, unused. About ten domestic and irrigation wells drilled 2002–2021, 135–180 ft. Golf course well, 175 ft, 2021. Midland Draw crosses the north half and has carried its name on every USGS sheet from 1954 to 2019 — it never disappeared; the ranch did. Powell’s 1876 notes call this “waters of North Concho.” Modern mapping drains it east to the Colorado by Midland Draw and Beak Creek; the North Concho is not on the path.

Soil. About 60% Amarillo and Midessa fine sandy loam — well drained, “farmland of statewide importance.” Bippus clay loam in the draws, subject to occasional flooding. No hydric soils. Water table below 80 in. A “sandy old farm with one sickly tree,” as the man who sold it put it in 1977.

Oil. Fourteen locations on the Commission’s map. Inside the line: a dry hole drilled by John R. Parish in December 1980; Exxon’s No. 1 of 1998, still producing; Petroplex’s Estes Burton 7 No. 3 (2005) and the 7-8 Unit No. 4 (2011); Fasken’s Aldridge 1208R (2009), after Henry Resources’ 1208 came up dry. Endeavor’s Stephens Fee No. 3 (2014), since plugged; and three permits that expired without a bit turning. Under the north line, the toes of three Occidental horizontals — the Easy Target wells — spudded within four days of each other in early 2024 from one pad two and a half miles north in Martin County, laterals of 24,000 to 26,000 feet that come south and stop a hundred feet inside this section. Their numbers carry Martin County’s code, and rightly: tested against 18,000 permits along this county line, the Commission’s code follows the surface hole every time. Two crude gathering lines — Oryx Midland Oil Gathering’s “Green Tree” system, 6.63 in, T-4 Permit 10611, issued in 2024 to serve those pads — and one 16-in gas line (ONEOK Westex, on Pioneer Natural Gas’s 1979 right-of-way) cross the north half. The leases are still named for the family.

Before the streets. Open rangeland on every USGS edition 1954–1985: oil wells, drill holes, a gravel pit, a pipeline. Streets first appear 1991. Built out by 2010.

The course. Summer 1977; two men buy 320 acres from the Estes family, one of them the head pro at Ranchland Hills. First National Bank finances it — \$8.9 million, later litigated. Dirt-trail access until 1980. The course opens July 1979; the members own it from March 1983; the north nine follows; rebuild 2018.

The measure. Powell called 1,900 varas on every side. The county’s polygon measures 1,910 to 1,926. The section holds about 650 acres against 640 patented — ten acres of survey excess that nobody has had to account for in 150 years. And the tilt is not his mistake: every section in Block 39 runs 14° off north. He ran his lines by needle and wrote the variation down without correcting for it; the whole block is the fossil of his compass.

COULD NOT BE CONFIRMED

Compiled from records, not walked. The following were looked for and not found, or found and not trusted:

- One dry hole, Well No. 1, plotted from the Commission’s hardcopy map with no API number on file. Its operator and date are in no digital record.
- What the first lot sold for. A course-front lot was asking \$55,000 that winter; the first deed of trust is indexed at a figure too small to believe.
- Any 1930s–40s aerial. A 1944 Air Force frame exists at TxGIO and is on order; it did not arrive in time for this edition.
- Where on the ranch the calves of 1916 and the reunion of 1921 were. Not on this section, which had no house in 1946; which of the family’s other sections is not known.
- If you know any of these, write. Second edition is free to anyone who corrects the first.

Sources. Texas General Land Office (patent, field notes, scrip). Midland County Clerk (deed records as cited). Midland Central Appraisal District (abstracts, parcels). USGS topoView and EarthExplorer (topographic sheets 1954–2019, features from the 1966 Northwest Midland 7.5’ sheet; aerials 1954, 1965, 1974, 1984, 1995). WellWiki, ezrcr, and texas-drilling mirrors of RRC permit and completion data; Midland Reporter-Telegram 1950–1999 via the Southwest Collection, Texas Tech University; Texas Comptroller entry records; USDA 1946 aerial (TxGIO); USDA NAIP 2002 (NAIP 2024 exists as a county mosaic in a proprietary format and was not used); Railroad Commission of Texas GIS and 2024 T-4 permit registers; Texas Water Development Board; USDA-NRCS Web Soil Survey; EPA WATERS / NHDPlus; federal court records as cited. Full source log, fifty-plus rows, at github.com/acw188/One-square-mile.

Gathered by Skippy (Meta Mus). Designed by Claude (Anthropic). Approved and paid for by a resident of the section, who is not named on it. No phone calls were made. Sheet oriented to the 1876 survey; true north 15° right of page-up. Scale 1:3,000. Aerial strip: each frame’s placement error is stated in its caption.